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FOR INDIA, CLARITY, NOT PANIC OR DENIAL

We must respond with steady engagement with Riyadh and a calibrated approach to the sabre-rattling



BY SYED AKBARUDDIN

The Saudi-Pakistan strategic mutual defence agreement signed on September 17 has sparked speculation across two seas and a subcontinent. One line matters: an attack on one is an attack on both. That line has stirred debate from the Gulf to the Himalayas over rewiring strategic playbooks. For India, the choice is clarity and posture, not panic or denial.

Why now? Start with Doha. On September 9, Israeli jets struck a safe house in the Qatari capital where Hamas leaders were weighing a ceasefire proposal. The blast rattled Gulf capitals, but fit a larger pattern of Israeli action this year across seven fronts: Gaza, Lebanon, Syria, Iran, Yemen, Tunisia and, now, Qatar. With little visible restraint from Washington, regional confidence is shaken and has fuelled speculation about the next flashpoint.

That is why layered defence is now doctrine. Houthi strikes from Yemen on Saudi regions Abqaiq and Khurais in 2019 were a hard lesson. Distance and deals do not stop drones or cruise missiles. Gulf states now build redundancy into policy, harden infrastructure and diversify supply chains. Disillusionment with great power protection is no longer theoretical. It is a hard fact.

What should India do? First, breathe. This pact formalises ties dating back to the 1960s. Pakistan's role in the Baghdad Pact and CENTO shows alliances do not automatically drag members into war. In 2015, Pakistan's Parliament vetoed joining the fight in Yemen. Domestic politics constrain Islamabad's commitments. The new agreement is deterrence by design, not an automatic war guarantee, and its operational feasibility is uncertain. That nuance matters for India.



Illustration by RAJ VERMA

INDIA MUST NOT REACT TO GULF SHIFTS. IN GEOPOLITICS, RESTRAINT IS NOT WEAKNESS, IT IS STRATEGY PERFORMED IN SILENCE

New Delhi's first read was right—vigilance without theatre. Now comes the harder part: reassurance without genuflecting. Saudi Arabia is India's vital energy partner and host to a large Indian diaspora. Bilateral relations are strong. The message to capital Riyadh should be delivered quietly. In any future India-Pakistan crisis, Riyadh's incentives to stay neutral remain overwhelming. Energy, investment, technology and a rising Indian market will weigh heavily. Bank those incentives with steady engagement, not podium outrage. Such messages land best in private, not in public.

Avoid the echo chamber. Work the quartet. India has close ties with Abu Dhabi, Doha, Tehran and Israel. These regional capitals shape escalation risks and create space for mediation. India's leverage with them is significant as conjecture over Gulf alignments intensifies.

India earned its equity in West Asia as a soft power that straddled divides. If the Gulf is building redundancies, India too must harden its own shield. This would help deter miscalculation or adventurism by an emboldened Pakistan. India should strengthen integrated air and missile defences. Scale counter-drone systems. Expand space-based maritime domain awareness. The best answer to a shadow is light: sharper detection, faster attribution, stronger preparation.

The domestic political din will be loud. Some will declare a diplomatic collapse. Others will sneer that it is theatre. Both miss the plot. This pact neither presages nuclear Armageddon in West Asia nor is it irrelevant. It has prompted analysis about Riyadh's unwillingness to bet the kingdom on a single guarantor.

The arrangement is as much about strategic signalling as it is about Saudi-Pakistan ties. Islamabad will leverage its position within this framework. Beijing is likely to work through Pakistan to deepen military ties with Riyadh. India should see the signals for what they are and respond with calculation, not emotion.

India must heed the changing geometry of its extended neighbourhood. That means not only reacting to Gulf shifts but shaping the order by being present, prepared and diplomatically proactive. Let others gamble. Calibrate, reinforce, and keep the Gulf close while quietly deepening ties. In geopolitics, restraint is not weakness. It is strategy performed in silence. The future will not judge India by how loudly it reacted but by how effectively it made this pact irrelevant to its broader ties. ■

The author was India's permanent representative at the United Nations